THE BIGGEST CATCH
Deepak Boxer (centre) with officers of the Delhi Police special cell and the Mexico police at the Istanbul airport on the way back to Delhi

Deepak 'Boxer' Pahal had been on the run since January across three continents, when the special cell of the Delhi Police finally arrested him on April 3 from Cancun, Mexico, just as he was about to launch into the last leg of his journey towards his final destination—the United States. It was the Delhi Police's first-ever overseas operation of its kind, conducted with the help of the Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI), the Interpol and the police in Mexico.

It all started in August 2022, when Special Commissioner Hargobinder Singh Dhaliwal asked his team to go after the big gangsters active in the National Capital Region. A list of the top 10 gangsters was drawn up, and Deepak Boxer figured right on top. A former junior national boxing champion—hence the sobriquet—the 27-year-old was wanted in multiple cases of murder and extortion. A native of Sonepat in Haryana, he had first shot into the limelight when he freed gang leader Jitendra Mann alias Gogi from police custody in 2016. After Gogi was killed in the Rohini courts complex in September 2021, Deepak took over as the head of the Gogi gang. His biggest crime was the murder of builder Amit Gupta in August 2022 in Delhi's Burari area. He was also said to be associated with Lawrence Bishnoi and the Canada-based Goldy Brar, the gangsters suspected to have conspired to kill singer Sidhu Moosewala in May 2022.

Once they identified him as the NCR's top gangster, the Delhi Police Special Cell launched a manhunt for Deepak, following his spoor across eight states—Delhi, Haryana, Himachal Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Maharashtra, Goa and Gujarat. One by one, the police caught most of his associates. However, with the noose tightening around him, Deepak managed to get a fake passport in January in the name of Ravi Antil.

It is at this point that the story turns really interesting. On January 6, Dhaliwal claims, Boxer flew from Kolkata to Dubai, to Almaty in Kazakhstan, to Istanbul, thence to Panama City and thereafter to the Port of Spain in February. From the Port of Spain, he flew to Suriname's capital, Paramaribo, and back to Panama City by February-end. From there, he took a flight to San Jose, capital of Costa Rica, and reached El Salvador on March 1. Then, he crossed Guatemala by road after which he entered Mexico. In nearly 100 days, Deepak took eight flights—all his destinations had a visa on arrival facility—and travelled aboard cars, boats and mini trucks en route to Mexico, from where he was plotting an escape to the US.

Helping Deepak were the members of his gang who were active in California, Portugal and Australia. It was his associates in the US that Deepak was planning to join before Dhaliwal & Co put a spanner in the works. According to the police, Deepak's associates in the US and Australia had arranged his travel to the US through what has come to be called the 'donkey route'—the journey across several countries that hundreds of desperate youth from South Asia undertake to seek a better future in western Europe, Canada and especially the US through the help of illegal traffickers in India and their facilitators, called 'donkers', who operate in foreign nations through which they transit. The name has its origins in a Punjabi idiom, meaning 'to hop from one place to another', and also refers to the beast of burden.

Cops believe that a nexus has now formed between gangsters trying to flee the country through the donkey route, human trafficking cartels in India and the West, as well as the operators who keep the system well-oiled through forged documents, safe houses and arrangement of money—the donkers. A Delhi Police special cell officer says that the information they are getting from interrogating Deepak is uncovering more about how the donkey route, now increasingly being favoured by criminals, actually operates.

Other than being assured of a ready refuge by their partners in crime, well-informed gangsters choose US, Canada and West Europe for another reason—authorities in India necessarily face a long legal battle to extradite them once they set foot in these countries. Knowing how liberal US laws are towards granting asylum to those who seek it on grounds of human rights violations, it was imperative for the Delhi Police team that they lay their hands on the redoubtable 'Boxer' before he crossed over from Mexico.

POLICE BELIEVE A NEXUS HAS FORMED BETWEEN GANGSTERS FLEEING INDIA, TRAFFICKING AGENTS AND THE DONKERS– FACILITATORS OF THE OPERATION

It is not just gangsters, though, who use the donkey route. Thousands from mainly